University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,353: Current Trends in Global Governance

ECTS credits: 4

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (25%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Active participation, Analog, Individual work individual grade (15%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (60%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,353,1.00 Current Trends in Global Governance -- English -- Dingwerth Klaus

Course information

Prerequisites

Basic knowledge of theories of international institutions is a requirement. This knowledge will usually have been acquired either in an introductory course on International Relations at BA-level or in the MIA core course "International Politics and Market Economy".

Students who have no background on Political Science and International Relations are welcome to attend the course and bring in their expertise, but they will need to catch up on international institutions outside of class. I will make 4-5 classical articles available on Canvas that students without a Political Science / IR background to ought to have read by week 3.

Learning objectives

- Students know, understand, and analyse basic concepts in the study of global governance.
- Students know, understand, and critically examine key trends in the study of global governance.
- Students engage in systematic empirical analysis of specific trends in specific issue areas of global governance.
- Students communicate their results effectively.

Content

Course description

Since the mid-1990s, a broad literature on 'global governance' has emerged. In this literature, global governance commonly refers to 'systems of rule at all levels of human activity – from the family to the international organization – in which the pursuit of goals through the exercise of control has transnational repercussions' (James Rosenau).

Following this definition, the goal of global governance research is to describe, map, analyse and assess world political transformations taking place since the 1990s. How and by whom is global governance conducted? Which forms does it take? And what consequences do the manifold structures and processes of global governance and for whom?

In recent years, however, public and academic debates have turned towards 'geopolitics'. The comeback of this older label suggests two things: first, that world politics has returned to a more state-centric mode of interaction. Second, that it has power considerations (as well as power shifts) have become a more dominant driving force in world politics again. But is this really true? And if so, what does it mean for the existing structures and processes of global governance?

Against this background, the course seeks to develop and test ideas for the creation of a 'Global Governance Observatory'. In the fall term 2026, this will include two main objectives:

(1) We seek to understand what is left of global governance and how the existing structures and processes of global governance in different issue areas of world politics respond to contemporary world political dynamics. In brief: What trends are emerging in these areas of global governance?

(2) The second goal is methodological: Besides discussing the trends themselves, we examine how we can best track current trends in global governance. This includes the question: Can AI tools help with this task – and if so, how?

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

Course structure

The course is divided in three parts. The first part (sessions 1-6) takes place in weekly sessions (90 minutes each). The second and third part take place in a workshop format on two Fridays (6 hours each).

In the first part of the course (sessions 1-6), we will (a) read and discuss some classical texts to gain a common understanding of how global governance has been conceptualized and studied so far. Moreover, we will (b) examine which major trends contemporary scholarships has identified in global governance

In the second part (sessions 7-9), we will mainly discuss which methods are suitable for identifying and tracing current trends in global governance. Questions include: What are good indicators for a specific trend? Which data could be used to measure them? Which data sources exist? How can the data best be analysed and integrated?)

Based on these discussions, students will then work on their assignment and map key trends in a specific issue area of global governance. The second workshop is reserved for a presentation of their results.

Literature

Abbott, K. W., & Faude, B. (2022). Hybrid institutional complexes in global governance. *The Review of International Organizations*,*17*(2), 263-291. DOI : 10.1007/s11558-021-09431-3

Avant, Deborah, Martha Finnemore, and Susan K. Sell, eds (2016) Who Governs the Globe? Cambridge: Cambridge UP.https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511845369

Dingwerth, K., & Pattberg, P. (2006). Global Governance as a Perspective on World Politics. *Global Governance*, *12*(2), 185–203. http://www.jstor.org/stable/27800609

Roger, C. (2020). *The Origins of Informality: Why the Legal Foundations of Global Governance are Shifting, and Why It Matters*. Oxford University Press.
DOI : 10.1093/oso/9780190947965.001.0001

Rosenau, J. N. (1995). Governance in the Twenty-first Century. *Global Governance*, *1*(1), 13–43. http://www.jstor.org/stable/27800099

Additional information

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Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	25%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

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Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids

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2. Examination sub part (2/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Active participation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Synchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	15%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

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Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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3. Examination sub part (3/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	60%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
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Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Content

(1) Active participation (individual, 15%): This facilitates learning by incentivizing regular participation and active engagement of students in the three parts: the “groundwork” (sessions 1-6), the methodological work (sessions 7-9), and the presentation and discussion of results (sessions 10-12).

(2) Written responses to required readings (individual, 25%): For sessions 2-6, students write five 1-page summaries of the core reading and, in doing so, respond to specific questions related to these readings. This will train writing skills (plus: writing is thinking). It also ensures that everyone comes to class well-prepared. This way, we can use contact hours for an in-depth discussion of the readings and their implications for a Global Governance Observatory. The use of AI is not permitted for this assignment.

(3) Synthesis paper on one trend (or: one issue area) (individual, 60%): In their synthesis papers, students map a specific trend (e.g., privatization; informalization; fragmentation; politicization) in a specific issue area of global governance. The papers will be around 4.500 words (incl. references) in length. Papers will be presented and discussed / defended in the final part of the course (sessions 10-12), if possible in the presence of invited experts on the fields we will cover.

To allow for genuine research, the issues we select will be relatively specific – e.g., the global governance of care work or e-commerce rather than “global economic governance”, the global governance of genocide prevention or of the protection of rights of internally displaced persons rather than “global security governance”, the global governance of fisheries or oceans plastics rather than “global environmental governance”, etc. The number of issues covered will depend on the number of students taking the course. In terms of issue selection, students will have some leeway to pursue topics of their own interest as long as (a) we can find groups of students working on the same issue area (to allow for a comprehensive assessment of trends

in that area), (b) the issues “make sense” from a case selection perspective, and (c) we can find experts in the relevant fields who are willing to comment on the final papers at the end of the term.

In the second part of the term, students will conduct their research on the specific trends. We will use sessions 7-9 to discuss common methodologies and preliminary results in groups that span either across trends (e.g., those studying politicization in different areas) or across issue areas (e.g., those studying different trends related to the global governance of lithium). In addition, we will develop a common structure and format for the synthesis papers during the course.

Eventually, the synthesis papers will allow us to test to what extent student coursework coming from an international network of universities could provide a basis for a future Global Governance Observatory. The papers will conclude with a short reflection on how this might best be achieved and what the limitations of such an approach could be.

Literature

Required readings will be made available on Canvas.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).